Rookies.

The matching architecture for early-career hiring.

Pitch · 2026

Confidential

The first job is a market.

And like any market, it only works when both sides can find each other. Today, they can't. We’re rebuilding the layer between them, from the mathematics up.

Four ways the market breaks.

The dysfunction isn't an accident — it's structural.

The visibility tax

Today's job platforms are subscription-driven advertising marketplaces. The 424,000 NL SMEs that would fit a student lose to a handful of well-marketed brands every cohort.

One-sided scoring

Existing platforms optimise for engagement, not for matching. Students filter by keyword; recruiters filter for keywords. Neither side's recommendation is informed by what the other side actually needs.

AI vs AI

Applicants tailor CVs with AI. Recruiters screen them with AI. The two systems negotiate, neither has ever met the person at the centre. The market has reduced itself to a single prayer.

Universities standing still

Career-office tooling was built before LLMs. No longitudinal tracking, no real-time labour-market view, no skills-gap intelligence. The institutions best positioned to fix the system can't see it.

The cost, in numbers.

From the Dutch early-career market, today.

120+

applications per junior role

7s

recruiter time per CV

3 in 4

applicants now use AI to apply

8 in 10

companies screen with AI in 2026

Getting your first job has become a game of chance. It does not have to be.

Three forces, converging this cohort.

The conditions that make this problem solvable now did not exist eighteen months ago.

01

AI has industrialised the dysfunction.

Generative AI didn't solve matching; it scaled the failure. The cycle worsens with each new cohort. The cost of waiting is paid by the next graduating class.

02

The EU AI Act now governs high-risk recruitment.

Article 13 mandates per-pair transparency. Existing platforms can't deliver it. We are built to comply from day one, explainable scoring is the product, not a patch.

03

Universities are being asked questions they can't answer.

Boards, faculty, and ministries need real-time outcome data. Career-office software from the pre-LLM era can't produce it. The first vendor that does becomes the default layer.

We replace the architecture.

Rookies is a matching architecture, not a job board. We pair quantitative scoring with explainable AI reasoning, embed natively in Dutch universities, and build a longitudinal community of students whose career trajectories compound the system's intelligence over time.

Quantitative scoring

Math first. Deterministic, auditable, fast.

Reasoning-layer AI

Rookies AI Agent for the signal math can't capture, with a rationale per pair.

Longitudinal community

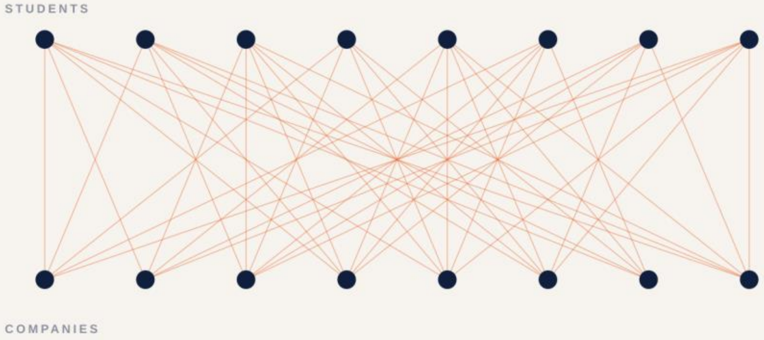
Cohort data that compounds. Each match teaches the system.

From spray to allocation.

The same students. The same companies. A different layer between them.

The market today.

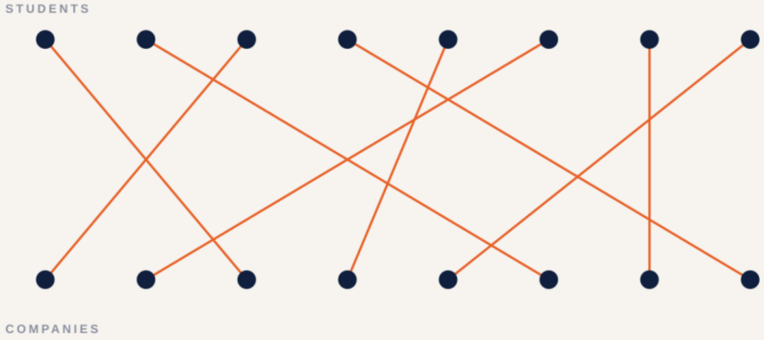
Visibility-driven. Engagement-optimised. Unallocated.



Today: every student applies to every company. 120 applications per role. 7 seconds per CV.

The market, modelled.

Stable matching. Two-sided preferences. Mutually fit.



Rookies: pool-aware ranking via Roth-Shapley. Mutual fit. Five candidates per role.

We do not rank harder. We change what is being ranked.

The mathematics is published.
The deployments are operational.

1962

Gale & Shapley

Stable matching.

1994

Nash

Equilibrium in strategic markets.

2012

Roth & Shapley

Nobel Prize — market design as engineering.

2025

NRMP

37,667 doctors placed in a single match.

Kidney exchange. School choice. Dynamic fleets. Moneyball. The early-career hiring market is the most prominent matching market that has not yet been redesigned.

Four layers no existing platform models together.

Each layer answers a different question. The combination is the product.

L1 Hard skills

Linear optimisation over structured features. Deterministic, auditable, fast — the kind of math an EU regulator can read.

L2 Soft skills

Rookies AI Agent reads CVs, projects, and self-descriptions. Math stays primary; AI extends its reach with a rationale per score.

L3 The market

Pool-aware ranking via Roth-Shapley. Fit is not absolute — it depends on who else is in the pool, in real time.

L4 Community

Longitudinal cohorts. Events, content, post-placement feedback. Each match teaches the next. The moat compounds.

Four products. One system.

Three sides of the market, finally pulling in the same direction.

Matchmaking architecture

Quant + reasoning AI feeding a stable-matching algorithm. EU AI Act compliant by construction.

Career-services analytics

Cohort outcomes, skills-gap intelligence, board-ready reports — the first such tooling in Dutch higher education.

SME & startup visibility

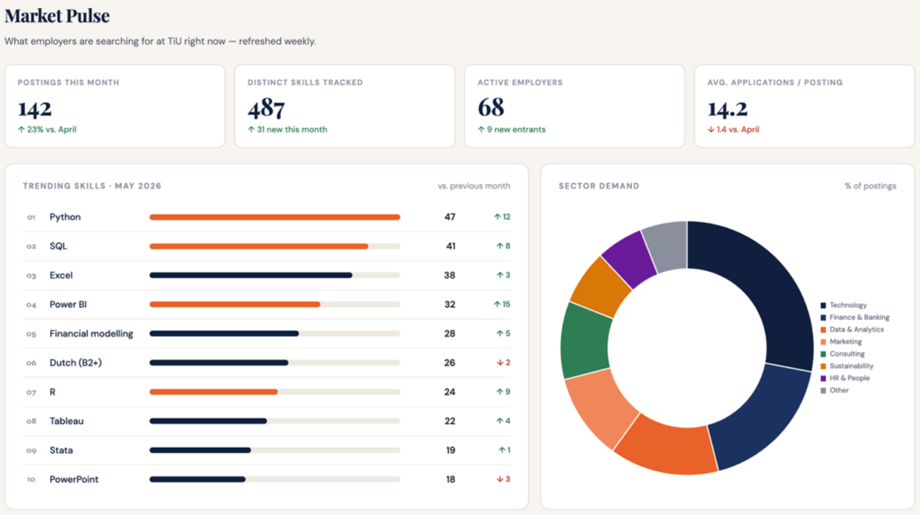
Free for every Dutch employer. Visibility set by match quality, not by paid placement.

Recruiter outreach

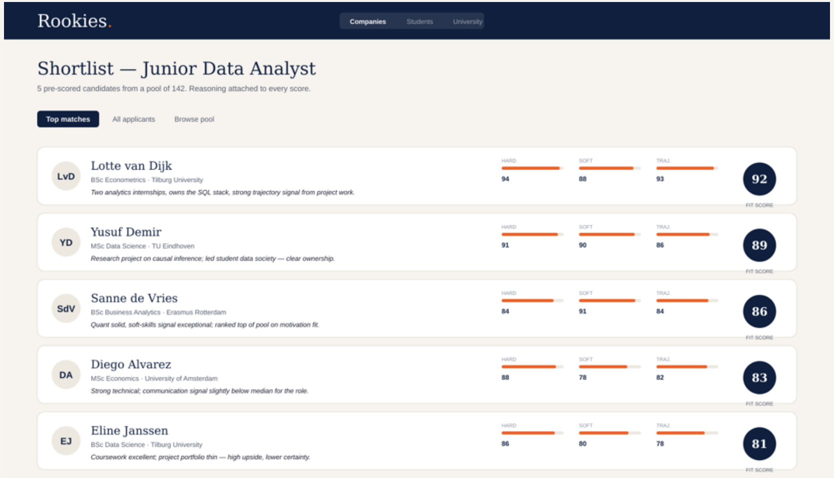
Pre-scored shortlists with explainable rationale. Five candidates ranked, not three hundred CVs to scan.

Built, not (only) pitched.

The beta version is operating. Two views below.



One of the tools of the Career Officer dashboard. Market Pulse



Recruiter shortlist. Rationale per score..

A focused home market. A continental prize.

NETHERLANDS

€100M

Total addressable, at maturity.

800K students · 50 institutions
183K graduates per year
424K SMEs · the visibility tax to solve

EUROPE

€2–3B

Total addressable, at maturity.

~5M higher-ed graduates per year
27 member states · one EU AI Act regime
Replication, not reinvention

Revenue path (bottom-up, conservative)

2026 **€60K ARR**	*2028* **€1.65M ARR**	*2030* **€13M+ ARR**
Tilburg pilot	*Dutch scale*	*EU rollout*

Rookies.

A flywheel, not a portfolio.

Three revenue streams. One compounding loop.

PRIMARY

Employer platform

Freemium → SaaS

Free posting and discovery for every Dutch employer. Paid tiers unlock preference tailoring, employer branding, and hiring analytics. The growth engine in Y1–2, the recurring base at scale.

DISTRIBUTION

University licenses

€5K–€15K / institution / year

Career-office software, cohort analytics, skills-gap intelligence. Not the revenue line — the moat and the qualification layer. Each university is worth multiples of its license in employer pull-through.

MARGIN

Brand partnerships

Add-on

Employers pay to host curated events, branded workshops, and sponsored trips with pre-screened Rookies cohorts. The community is the moat; this is how it monetizes.

Universities first. Everything follows.

Trusted distribution beats direct outbound at the early-career layer.

01	2026 Tilburg + 2 anchors	Founding team embedded at Tilburg. Academic advisor on faculty.
02	2027 Top 14 research universities	Replicate. Employer demand pulled by trusted university partners — no cold outbound. Default early-career layer of Dutch research-university system.
03	2028+ All 50 institutions, then EU	Universities of applied sciences. Belgium, Germany, the wider EU. Same playbook, multilingual matching engine.

Win universities first. Students follow. Employers follow. The network compounds.

Rookies.

Everyone solves a fragment. *We built the system.*

	Matching Algorithm	Early career focused?	Uni-embedded	Community / Longitudinal	Career Officer tool
JobTeaser	AI – recruiters only	No	Partial	No	No
Magnet.me	Filters based	Partial	No	Partial	No
LinkedIn / Indeed	Basic AI-LLM	No	No	No	No
Rookies	Econometric model + AI positioning + Market Optimization	✓	✓	✓	✓

JobTeaser last raised in 2019. Magnet.me has been capital-constrained since 2017. LinkedIn and Indeed aren't built for the early-career segment, and none of them optimizes the available market — different economics, different signal.

Three people, one architecture.

“I built this because I lived this market. I watched friends spray-apply to three hundred jobs and end up working in something they didn't choose. The market doesn't have to be a lottery. The mathematics is solved. We just have to ship it.”

— Dan Toma Poenaru, founder

Dan Toma Poenaru

Co-founder & CEO

MSc Business Analytics & OR, BSc IBA — Tilburg University. Designing the algorithm. Product, partnerships, fundraising.

Tudor Octavian Poenaru

Co-founder & CTO

BSc Computer Science & Engineering — TU Eindhoven. Leads the back-end, connectivity and deployment.

Dr. Cristian Dobre

Academic Advisor

Associate Professor, Econometrics & OR, Tilburg. Master Academic Director, Business Analytics & OR (TiSEM). Advisor on the mathematics behind the matching algorithm.

ROOKIES

“Travel like a human” was Airbnb's first conviction.

“Find work like a human” is ours.

Thank you – Rookies Team